

MEMORY — VISUAL & COLOR-CODED MASTER NOTE (PSY 101)

1. What is Memory?

Memory is the mental process of encoding, storing, and retrieving information. It determines why we remember some experiences and forget others.

2. Bottom-Up & Top-Down Influences

Bottom-Up: Raw sensory input (what we see/hear).

Top-Down: Prior knowledge, expectations, and experiences that shape memory.

3. Three Stages of Memory

Encoding: Transforming sensory input into memory.

Storage: Maintaining information over time.

Retrieval: Accessing information when needed.

4. Three-Stage Model of Memory

Sensory Memory → Short-Term Memory → Long-Term Memory.

Rehearsal moves information from STM to LTM.

5. Sensory Memory

Brief storage of sensory impressions (sight, sound, touch, smell, taste). Most details fade rapidly.

6. Digit Span & STM Capacity

Average capacity: 7 ± 2 items.

Digit Span examples: 6194, 37852, 965283, 4269851, 81637249

7. Short-Term Memory (STM)

Limited capacity. Chunking uses prior knowledge to expand storage. STM can miscode information.

8. Long-Term Memory (LTM)

Implicit Memory: Unconscious skills (e.g., riding a bike).

Explicit Memory: Conscious facts & events (e.g., remembering a birthday).

9. Organization & Meaning

Memory improves when information is meaningful or grouped logically (e.g., ABCDEFGHI vs GDCEIAHBF).

10. Primacy & Recency Effects

Primacy Effect = First items → LTM.

Recency Effect = Last items → STM.

11. Levels of Processing

Shallow Processing (appearance) → Weak memory.

Deep Processing (meaning) → Strong memory.

12. Ebbinghaus' Forgetting Curve

Memory loss is rapid at first, then slows over time. Immediate recall highest.

13. Interference Theory

Proactive Interference: Old info blocks new.

Retroactive Interference: New info blocks old.

14. Flashbulb Memories

Emotionally intense memories. Highly vivid but still prone to distortion. People are overly confident in them.

15. Improving Memory

Study repeatedly; deepen meaning; use cues; mnemonics; reduce interference; sleep well; exercise; self-test; stay organized; eat healthy; use self-reference.